

Common Business English Mistakes

Business English is crucial for professional success. While you may be confident in your general English skills, the workplace presents unique challenges. This lesson explores 5 common mistakes that might be hurting your career progress. By understanding and avoiding these errors, you'll enhance your communication skills and navigate the professional world more effectively. Let's explore how you can boost your business English proficiency!



Mistake 5: Being unable to handle difficult conversations.

Difficult conversations are part of our professional lives. However, many of us don't feel comfortable having awkward conversations because **we don't know the best way to approach them**. It's hard enough if you're proficient in a language, but if you're still learning, it can be even more challenging.

A business English programme should **teach you how to deal with awkward conversations professionally**.

Whether you're -

- firing someone
- being fired
- entering a tough negotiation with a client
- talking to a colleague about areas for improvement

You should feel confident that your English can handle it.

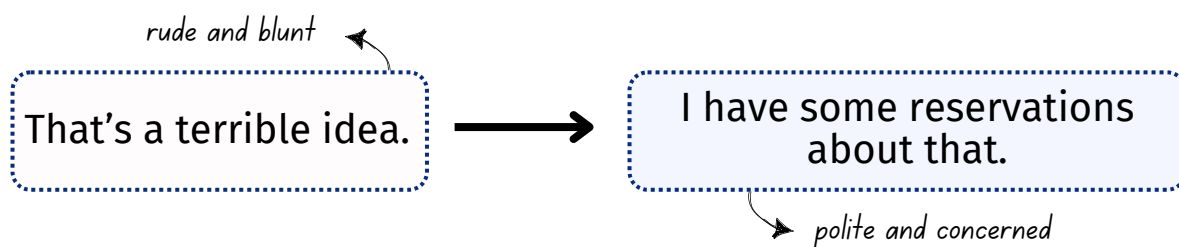
Go from -

I'm firing you!

↘ *harsh and direct*



professional and gentle ↖
We're letting you go.



Mistake 4: Only learning formal language.

My team here at English with Lucy is quite diverse, and we're spread all over the world, but English is the bridge that connects us.

This shared language allows us to -

- form strong relationships with each other
- tell (and understand!) jokes
- share our news and support each other

I want you to experience this too in YOUR international company!

a relationship where people feel comfortable and connected

If you have a good **rapport** with your colleagues, clients, students, patients and so on, you'll be able to work together more effectively, and your working environment will be much more pleasant.

To create strong connections, **you need to be relaxed and be yourself**, which means dropping the formal register. And that's why an effective professional English programme should teach formal and less formal language.

So, which of these sentences is more appropriate when speaking to a client you're friendly with?

I wish you the best of luck.

I'll cross my fingers for you! ✓

My move up the career ladder was fairly slow.

I slowly worked my way up from the bottom! ✓

You can use those lovely formal phrases with people you have a less close relationship with.



Mistake 3: Not being able to talk about your successes.

A lot of people are uncomfortable discussing their accomplishments. We often feel like we're bragging: "**Oh, I'm the best employee in the world!**" But being able to talk about your achievements at work can have a direct positive effect on your career.

It's so much harder to get promoted or get a new job if you don't know how to talk about your successes! A good professional English programme will **teach you how to share your wins**. You'll be able to say things like -

"I'm really proud that I got that project off the ground."

and

"I took the initiative to manage the budget and was able to cut costs significantly."



Mistake 2:

Learning what to say but not how to say it.

Maybe your experience of English is relatively passive and you **spend most of your time reading reports or listening to colleagues**. Or maybe your previous teachers never really paid much attention to pronunciation so **you recognise loads of vocabulary but don't feel confident using it**. Learning what to say but not how to say it can -

- prevent you from effectively memorising the phrase
- leave you feeling shy or even
- cause a complete breakdown in communication if your pronunciation is unclear

That's why I focus so heavily on pronunciation in this programme. Let's take a few words and phrases that have come up in this video so far. How confident do you feel saying these out loud?

- colleague
- many of us shy away from
- We're letting you go.

Did you stress the first syllable in **colleague** /'kɒli:g/ and use the **long vowel sound /i:/**? Or did the word sound more like **college** /'kɒlɪdʒ/?

It's not just individual sounds and word stress that matter when it comes to accurate pronunciation. I'll also teach you how to confidently read longer phrases like '**many of us shy away from**' /'meni jəv ʌs ʃaɪ jə'weɪ frəm/ with accurate sentence stress and linking sounds. And what about the last statement? I hope you said:

Falling Intonation

We're letting you go.

Rising Intonation

We're letting you go.

"We're letting you go." with rising intonation can convey uncertainty or even change a statement into a question - **that's how important intonation is!** You'll also see how learning about these pronunciation features can massively improve your listening skills. It's a win-win!



Mistake 1:

Thinking business English has to be boring.

It might not be a big secret, but **a lot of business English programmes are a bit dull.**

A professional English programme shouldn't just teach you how to discuss facts and figures. Don't get me wrong, I love giving my students the language to talk about statistics and trends. But that's not all you need to learn.

A well-rounded professional English programme will focus on up-to-date, relevant subjects like **mental health at work, coaching and training programmes** and **how to use inclusive language**. Whatever your profession, you'll probably need to learn the **language to mediate conflicts, share your work on social media** and **give constructive feedback**.

The way the material is delivered matters, too. Business English is much more interesting when it's taught through **engaging videos, relatable stories following people's professional challenges and successes, interactive exercises** and **a vibrant community of other professional learners**.



Activity

Choose the correct answer for each question.

1. Why is it important to learn how to talk about your successes?
 - a. to impress your colleagues
 - b. to have a direct positive effect on your career
 - c. to prove you're better than others
2. What aspect of professional English learning is often neglected?
 - a. vocabulary
 - b. grammar
 - c. pronunciation
3. Why is intonation important in business English?
 - a. It can change the meaning of what you're saying.
 - b. It makes you sound more sophisticated.
 - c. It helps you speak faster.
4. Which phrase is given as an example of a more conversational way to express support?
 - a. "I wish you the best of luck."
 - b. "I'll cross my fingers for you!"
 - c. "May fortune favour your endeavours."
5. What does the lesson suggest about formal language in business English?
 - a. It's the only important aspect to learn.
 - b. It should be avoided entirely.
 - c. It should be balanced with less formal language.
6. Which of these is listed as one of the top 5 business English mistakes to avoid?
 - a. using too much technical jargon
 - b. being unable to handle difficult conversations
 - c. speaking too quickly in meetings
7. Which of these is given as an example of a more professional way to express disagreement?
 - a. "That's a terrible idea."
 - b. "I have some reservations about that."
 - c. "You're completely wrong."
8. What is the relationship between pronunciation and listening skills?
 - a. improving pronunciation can also improve listening skills
 - b. they are unrelated skills
 - c. good listening skills naturally lead to perfect pronunciation

Answers:

a (8) b (2) c (5) a (4) b (5) c (3) a (1) b (8)

